ADRIANO MONTEIRO

NUTRITION COACH

Nutrition Fundamentals for Transformation

The Practical Guide

Bonus Guide | Transform Method

adrianonutrition.com

Contents

1. Introduction: Beyond the Myths
2. Energy Balance: The Unskippable First
3. Macronutrients: The Building Blocks
4. Meal Structuring & Nutrient Timing
5. Evidence-Based Supplementation
6. Conclusion: Build Your System

Disclaimer. This guide is for informational and educational purposes only and complements the "Nutrition Myths Exposed" guide. It is not a substitute for professional medical or dietetic advice. The author is a certified nutrition coach and student, not a registered dietitian or medical doctor. Consult with a qualified healthcare professional before making any significant changes to your diet or exercise routine. The information provided is based on current scientific evidence, but individual needs may vary.

Introduction: Beyond the Myths

In "Nutrition Myths Exposed," we dismantled the most common absurdities in the fitness industry. We learned what not to do. But that only solves half the problem. Now it is time to build a solid foundation of what to do.

This guide is the essential next step. It is a practical, science-based manual for building a nutritional strategy that fuels your transformation, supports your health, and fits your life. There are no magic tricks here, just proven principles that work.

We will cover the "big rocks" of nutrition: **energy balance, macronutrients, meal structuring, and supplementation.** By mastering these fundamentals, you will gain the confidence and competence to navigate your nutritional journey without falling for the next fad diet.

Let's build your strategy, one evidence-based block at a time.

CHAPTER 1

Energy Balance: The Unskippable First

The principle

Energy balance is the foundation of weight management. It is not a theory. It is a law of thermodynamics.

- **Caloric deficit:** to lose weight, you must consume fewer calories than you expend.
- **Caloric surplus:** to gain weight, you must consume more calories than you expend.
- **Caloric maintenance:** to maintain your weight, you must consume the same amount of calories you expend.

Every successful diet, from Keto to Vegan, works by creating a caloric deficit.[1] The method is just the tool. The deficit is the mechanism.

How to estimate your caloric needs

No calculator is perfect, but the Mifflin-St Jeor equation is considered one of the most accurate for estimating your Basal Metabolic Rate (BMR), the calories you burn at rest.[2]

Step 1. Calculate your BMR

- **Men:** (10 × weight in kg) + (6.25 × height in cm) − (5 × age in years) + 5
- **Women:** (10 × weight in kg) + (6.25 × height in cm) − (5 × age in years) − 161

Step 2. Calculate your Total Daily Energy Expenditure (TDEE)

Multiply your BMR by an activity factor:

Activity level	Description	Multiplier
Sedentary	Little or no exercise	BMR × 1.2
Lightly active	Light exercise or sports, 1-3 days a week	BMR × 1.375
Moderately active	Moderate exercise or sports, 3-5 days a week	BMR × 1.55
Very active	Hard exercise or sports, 6-7 days a week	BMR × 1.725
Extra active	Very hard exercise and a physical job	BMR × 1.9

This TDEE is your estimated maintenance calorie level.

Step 3. Set your goal

- **For fat loss:** subtract 300-500 calories from your TDEE. This creates a sustainable deficit of 0.5-1% of body weight loss per week, which is optimal for preserving muscle mass.[3]
- **For muscle gain:** add 200-300 calories to your TDEE. This provides enough energy to build muscle with minimal fat gain.

> **Important note**
>
> This is a starting point. You must track your progress and adjust your intake based on real-world results.

CHAPTER 2

Macronutrients: The Building Blocks

Once your calorie target is set, we divide those calories among the three macronutrients: protein, fats, and carbohydrates.

1. Protein: the most important macro for transformation

Protein is crucial for muscle repair and growth and for satiety (feeling full). It also has the highest Thermic Effect of Food (TEF), meaning your body burns more calories digesting it.[4]

- **Target:** 1.6 to 2.2 grams of protein per kilogram of body weight (or 0.7 to 1.0 grams per pound).
- This range is consistently shown in research to be optimal for muscle retention during fat loss and for muscle growth during a surplus.[5]
- 1 gram of protein = 4 calories.

2. Fats: essential for hormones and health

Dietary fats are essential for hormone production (including testosterone), vitamin absorption, and overall health. They are not the enemy.

- **Target:** 20-30% of your total daily calories should come from fats.
- This ensures you get enough essential fatty acids without displacing protein and carbs.
- 1 gram of fat = 9 calories.

3. Carbohydrates: the primary fuel source

Carbohydrates are the body's preferred source of energy, especially for high-intensity exercise like CrossFit. They replenish muscle glycogen, which is essential for performance and recovery.

- **Target:** fill the rest of your daily calories with carbohydrates.
- 1 gram of carbohydrate = 4 calories.

Putting it all together: an example

Let's say our example person has a fat loss target of 2,000 calories and weighs 80 kg (176 lbs).

Macro	Calculation	Result
Protein	80 kg × 2.0 g/kg = 160 g, and 160 g × 4 kcal/g	640 kcal
Fats	2,000 kcal × 25% = 500 kcal, and 500 ÷ 9 kcal/g	about 56 g
Carbohydrates	2,000 − 640 − 500 = 860 kcal, and 860 ÷ 4 kcal/g	about 215 g

Daily target

160 g protein / 56 g fat / 215 g carbs

CHAPTER 3

Meal Structuring & Nutrient Timing

While what you eat is most important, when you eat can improve satiety, performance, and adherence.

Meal frequency

As we learned in "Nutrition Myths," eating 6 small meals does not "boost" your metabolism compared to 3 larger meals. The best meal frequency is the one that you can stick to consistently and that manages your hunger best.

Recommendation: aim for 3-5 meals per day, each containing a significant source of protein (20-40 g). This helps to maximize muscle protein synthesis throughout the day.[6]

Nutrient timing: does it matter?

For most people, nutrient timing is less important than hitting your total daily targets. However, for active individuals, some simple timing strategies can help.

- **Pre-workout (1-2 hours before):** a meal with easily digestible carbohydrates and some protein. This provides fuel for your session. Example: Greek yogurt with berries, or a chicken and rice bowl.
- **Post-workout (within 1-2 hours after):** a similar meal to replenish glycogen stores and provide protein for muscle repair.

The "anabolic window" is not a 30-minute emergency, but it is beneficial to get nutrients in within a couple of hours post-exercise.[7]

The 80/20 rule: flexibility vs. rigidity

Sustainable nutrition is not about perfection. The 80/20 rule is a powerful mindset for long-term success.

- **80%** of your calories come from whole, minimally processed, nutrient-dense foods (lean proteins, fruits, vegetables, whole grains).
- **20%** of your calories can come from foods you enjoy simply for pleasure.

This approach prevents the all-or-nothing thinking that leads to the binge-restrict cycle. It allows for social events, treats, and flexibility without guilt.

CHAPTER 4

Evidence-Based Supplementation

The supplement industry is full of hype. Most products are a waste of money. Here are the few supplements with strong scientific backing for performance and health.

Supplement	What it does and why it works	Recommended dose
Creatine monohydrate	Increases strength, power output, and muscle mass by regenerating ATP (the body's main energy currency). It is the most studied and effective sports supplement available.[8]	3-5 grams per day, every day. No need to cycle or load.
Whey or casein protein	A convenient and cost-effective way to increase your daily protein intake and meet your protein target. Supports muscle repair and growth.	1-2 scoops per day, as needed.
Vitamin D3	Essential for bone health, immune function, and hormone regulation. Many people are deficient, especially those with limited sun exposure.	1,000-4,000 IU per day, ideally taken with a source of fat. Get your blood levels checked to determine your specific need.
Omega-3 fatty acids (EPA/DHA)	Reduces inflammation, supports cardiovascular health, and may improve brain function. Found in fatty fish, but supplementation can be beneficial.	1-3 grams of combined EPA and DHA per day.

What about pre-workouts?

Most pre-workout formulas are a mix of caffeine and other under-dosed ingredients. A simple cup of coffee (100-200 mg of caffeine) 30-60 minutes before a workout is a cheaper and equally effective alternative for most people.[9]

Conclusion: Build Your System

This guide has given you the fundamental tools to build a robust and effective nutrition strategy. The path to a sustainable transformation is not about finding the perfect diet. It is about building a personalized system.

Your action plan

1. **Calculate your targets.** Use the formulas in Chapters 1 and 2 to set your starting calorie and macro goals.
2. **Plan your meals.** Decide on a meal frequency that fits your life and helps you hit your protein target in 3-5 meals.
3. **Focus on whole foods (80/20).** Build your diet around lean proteins, vegetables, fruits, and whole grains, while allowing for flexibility.
4. **Consider key supplements.** Start with the basics like creatine and protein powder if needed.
5. **Track and adjust.** Monitor your progress for 2-4 weeks. If you are not seeing the desired results, make small adjustments to your calorie intake (±100-200 calories) and repeat.

This process is one of self-experimentation and learning. Be patient, be consistent, and trust the science. You now have the knowledge to build a nutritional foundation that will last a lifetime.

Want a plan built around your life?

This guide gives you the tools. Turning them into a plan for your body, your schedule and your food preferences is where coaching helps. Let's talk about where you are and what to do next.

Book your free 20-minute call

https://calendly.com/adriano-nutrition/free-20-min-discovery-call

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